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Patrizia Dogliani

A Political History
of the International
Union of Socialist
Youth 1907–1917

palgrave
macmillan

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ISSN 2524-7123

ISSN 2524-7131 (electronic)

Marx, Engels, and Marxisms

ISBN 978-3-031-20693-1

ISBN 978-3-031-20694-8 (eBook)

<https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-20694-8>

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Cover illustration: Man_Half-tube

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INTRODUCTION

The creation and early life of the International Union of Socialist Youth attracted little resonance among historians and had few rare testimonies: some reconstructions took place early, particularly in the late 1920s, when the international communist and socialist youth unions vied for the primogeniture of labor youth movements and the legitimacy of its political continuity. Till the 1970s, histories of the Second International forgot all the existence of a youth international; works marked by congresses, such as those of James Joll, Roland Bauer, Julius Braunthal, Gerhart Niemeyer or Patricia Van der Esch, or those devoted to the ideas that guided the events of international socialism, such as the works of Georges D. H. Cole and Carl Landauer, had yet to delve into topics like the women's and youth movements and their social and political requests.

Only Van der Esch mentioned the existence of the “parallel” international unions associated with the Second International, like the Socialist Inter-parliamentary Commission, or the womens' international organization, but she too neglected to mention the Youth one. The French historian Annie Kriegel was more forthcoming, recalling its existence in a few lines, not least because her work expressed the need to treat the history of the International “as an element of contemporary social history.”¹ She understood the history of Union was a chapter in a more

¹ A. Kriegel. *Les internationales ouvrières (1864–1943)*. Paris, 1964, 7; and P. Van der Esch. *La Deuxième Internationale 1889–1923*. Paris, 1957.

complex political and social story of the working-class masses in the industrial era. The historical reconstruction of the Youth International was also limited by the narrowness of the sources used to write an “official” history of the Second International, which essentially consisted of congressional reports. It took the expansion of socialist *événementielle* history through Georges Haupt’s enormous survey and retrieval work in the 1960s to formulate projects for a study of “parallel and minor” international organizations. It was in fact Georges Haupt, in a distant 1977, who nudged me toward this history as the subject of my Italian university dissertation. In that year, Italy was troubled by a complex issue of youth, resulting in protests, alternative cultures and violence. The question of young generations emerged also in the social and political history of the workers’ movement.

The hesitation was attributed to the scarcity of sources and autobiographical narratives. Few accounts from that time were preserved for us, such as those of first secretaries Henri de Man and Willy Münzenberg; they were largely distorted by the ideological and political clash among national organizations that occurred with the Great War, in the aftermath of the Russian Revolution and at the birth of the Third International. The exception was what remained of the correspondence of the second secretary of the Union: the Austrian Robert Danneberg. Part of letters and congress preparatory documents went to the archives of the International Institute of Social History in Amsterdam, while much of the documentation from the secretariats operating in Vienna and Zurich was dispersed or handed over to the international communist youth movement in Moscow, which made instrumental use of it between the two-world-wars period.

The first reconstruction of the Union, and in part the only one, dates from 1929 to 1931 and was carried out by three leaders of the Communist Youth International: the Austrian Richard Schüller, the German Alfred Kurella and Russian Rafael Chitarov. Schüller was particularly concerned with reconstructing the first period, the one before the intervening partition between socialist and communist youth.² In the late 1920s, the authors were still involved in the clash between the two international youth organizations, the socialist and the communist ones, and communist interest was to discredit the earlier work of some young

² *Geschichte der Kommunistischen Jugendinternationale*, 3 vols, Berlin, 1929–1931: R. Schüller. *Von den Anfängen der proletarischen Jugendbewegung bis zur Gründung der KJI*.

socialist leaders—especially those who after the war remained loyal to or returned to the socialist “old house.” Even before a history was finished, a historiography had begun to undermine interpretation and the historical reconstruction of events. Any young leader in the 1920s was barred from these interpretative manipulations.³ The three youth internationals (the socialist, the communist and the third one based in Vienna) that sprang up in the immediate postwar period sought to legitimize themselves as the continuation of the one that was born in Stuttgart in 1907. In the second postwar, this first imprint remained. Most of the studies on the socialist youth came from East German historiography; and for several reasons: narrative continuity, easy access to German language sources and lack of interest from broader international historiography. To the already flawed pre-1945 understanding, other unsubstantiated interpretations were added, for example the GDR historians’ overestimation of the influence on the youth international movement by the Bolsheviks and Lenin before 1917.⁴

However, it must also be remembered that Stalinism and Nazism would soon eliminate, in purges, extermination camps, and through political assassinations, the protagonists of the history we are reconstructing here: Robert Danneberg, Willi Münzenberg, Gyula Alpari, to mention only the most important ones. Or many lesser-known Italians, who nonetheless played a key role together with the Swiss in saving the International Union from disappearing during the Great War. Several of them contributed to the birth of the Communist Youth International, and in the 1920s sought protection from fascism in Soviet Union and disappeared in the Stalinist purges. Robert Danneberg, a socialist and a Jew, died in Auschwitz in 1942. After the repression of the Hungarian revolution, the life of Gyula Alpari was a constant flight across Europe to escape the Stalinists, and then the Nazis, until he was killed in the Sachsenhausen concentration camp in 1944. All that does not include the still unsolved cause of Münzenberg’s death in a French forest in June 1940.

³ See the historical reconstruction made by three socialist leaders: L. Thaller. *Die internationale sozialistische Jugendbewegung*. Wien 1921; K. Korn. *Die Arbeiterjugendbewegung*. 2 vols., Berlin, 1923, and K. Heinz. *Kampf und Aufstieg*, Wien, 1932.

⁴ K.H. Jahnke (ed), *Geschichte der deutschen Arbeiterjugendbewegung 1904–1945*, Berlin (GDR) 1973; and A. Reinhardt. *Rolle und Funktion des Sekretariats der «Internationalen Verbindung sozialistischer Jugendorganisationen» (Entstehung und Tätigkeit 1907–1917)*. Ph. Diss., Leipzig, 1965.

This book had its first Italian version in 1983.⁵ It was the result of long research thanks to a fellowship at the Einaudi Foundation in Turin. It retains its original structure, although it is, for reasons of space, reduced in the very rich set of notes that almost constituted a second text in itself. The decision to rewrite and publish it in English stems from two main reasons. First: the lack of an international knowledge on this history. Secondly, the different approach and reading we can do of that history today.⁶ If the factual reconstructions of the history of the Second International have not progressed very far, the history of internationalism has made great strides. We can relocate this work in a new debate on the characteristics and limits of internationalism and transnationalism. The national movements, the struggles and goals they set: anti-militarism, protection of young workers from exploitation, access to culture and professional qualification for poor youth, economic and political networks among youths from different countries are now the dominant themes of a history of internationalism that not only examines organizations. Paraphrasing what was written by Glenda Sluga and Patricia Clavin “when historians addressed internationalism, they presume its nineteenth-century origins in Marxist-inspired political movements.”⁷ They showed that we can study other kinds of internationalism, from liberal-inclined internationalisms to a trans-nationalism led by international ideas and institutions. I would like to show here that the Marxism internationalism of the Second International, 1889–1917, can also be seen from the perspective of trans-national networks and struggles. And at the same time, the history of the International Union of Socialist Youth

⁵ P. Dogliani. *La “scuola delle reclute”. L’Internazionale giovanile socialista dalla fine dell’Ottocento alla Prima guerra mondiale*. Turin, 1983.

⁶ I refer to some of my previous considerations: Dogliani (ed). *Internazionalismo e transnazionalismo all’indomani della Grande Guerra*. Bologna, 2020, 7–26, *Socialisme et internationalisme. Histoires du socialisme: Cahiers Jaurès*, janvier-mars 2009, n. 191, 11–30. A different approach can be seen in few new books crossing internationalism and transnationalism: T.C. Imlay. *The Practice of Socialist Internationalism. European Socialists and International Politics 1914–1960*. Oxford, 1918; N. Delalande. *La lutte et l’entraide. L’âge des solidarités ouvrières*. Paris, 2019; E. Marcobelli. *Internationalism towards Diplomatic Crisis. The Second International and French, German and Italian Socialists*. Published in this collection, 2021.

⁷ G. Sluga and P. Clavin (eds). *Internationalism. A Twentieth-Century History*. Cambridge, 2017, 3. In this book, see also the chapters: Dogliani. The fate of Socialist Internationalism, 38–60, and T. Imlay. Socialist Internationalism after 1914, 191–212.

can be framed in the history of generation and relations between youth and adults as it has been developed in recent decades. The book is also a reflection on how and why large masses of European young workers were attracted to socialism and Marxism from the end of the nineteenth century up to the early twentieth century.

As I hand the book over to the press, I want to remember some *maestri* who at various times guided and influenced my early studies on the history of international socialism: Gian Mario Bravo, Enzo Collotti, Georges Haupt, Madeleine Rebérioux, Herbert Steiner, Claude Willard. My remembrance and thanks go to them. I would also like to thank those who allowed this book to be published: Francesca Antonini, Jean Numa Ducange, Marcello Musto, and the reviser of my English text, Alex Clark.

A brief notice about the notes: as it has been mentioned they have been reduced. An essential choice has been made of bibliographical references, quotations and data appearing in the footnotes, while archival references, pamphlets and newspaper articles have been largely indicated and are quoted here in their original language, as they appeared at the time, to better enable their identification and retrieval.

Bologna, September 2022

PRAISE FOR *A POLITICAL HISTORY OF THE INTERNATIONAL UNION OF SOCIALIST YOUTH 1907–1917*

“Patrizia Dogliani’s new history of the International Union of Socialist Youth draws fresh air into the often claustrophobic spaces of the history of socialism. She reminds us of the interests and agency of a young generation—in Europe and the wider world—in a volatile period of political experimentation and ambition, war and peace.”

—Glenda Sluga, *Professor of International History and Capitalism, HEC European University Institute, Florence, Italy*

“With this new book, Patrizia Dogliani once again demonstrates why she is one of the preeminent scholars of modern international and transnational history. Rooted in an impressive array of published and unpublished sources in multiple languages, Dogliani’s study of the International Union of Socialist Youth provides a novel window on the international socialist movement before and during World War I, highlighting the efforts of young European militants to define and instantiate socialism against a tumultuous background of depression, war and revolution. It is an impressive achievement.”

—Talbot Charles Imlay, *Professor, University of Laval, Quebec, Canada*

“Long recognized as a pioneering historian of youth, Patrizia Dogliani offers a rich transnational panorama of socialist youth across Europe. She persuasively links the birth of political rebellion and organizing among young people to the invention of ‘adolescence’ as a particular economic,

social, and cultural stage of modern life. With an impressive command of sources in multiple languages, Dogliani provides an essential guide to political activism among youth across class, gender, and nationality.”

—Mary Gibson, *Professor of History, City University of New York, USA*

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ABBREVIATIONS

AJI	Arbeiter-Jugend-Internationale (Berlin)
Am IISG (aJI)	Amsterdam: Internationaal Instituut voor Sociale Geschiedenis. Archives Socialistische-Jugend-Internationale.
Av	<i>L'Avanguardia</i> (Rome)
BSI	Bureau socialiste international
CGL	Confederazione Generale del Lavoro
CGT	Confédération générale du Travail
CYI	Communist Youth International Union
FIGS	Federazione italiana giovanile socialista, Rome: Italian socialist youth Federation
GRS	Karl Liebknecht, Gesammelte Reden und Schriften
IASJ	Internationale Arbeitsgemeinschaft sozialistischer Jugendorgan- isation (Vienna)
JA	<i>Der Jugendliche Arbeiter</i> (Vienna)
JI	<i>Jugend-Internationale</i> (Zurich -Berlin)
Mi BIF	Milan: GG. Feltrinelli Foundation's Library
MS	<i>Le Mouvement Socialiste</i> , Paris
NZ	<i>Die Neue Zeit</i> , Berlin
POB	Parti Ouvrier Belge
POF	Parti Ouvrier français
POSR	Parti ouvrier socialiste révolutionnaire
PSF	Parti socialiste de France
PSI	Partito socialista italiano
PSR	Parti socialiste révolutionnaire
PSS	Parti socialiste suisse
SFIO	Section française de l'Internationale ouvrière

SIUSY	Secretariat of the International Union of Socialist Youth/ Internationales Sekretariat der sozialistischen Jugendorganisationen /Bureau internationale des jeunesses socialistes, Vienna
SPD	Sozialdemokratische Partei Deutschlands
SYI	Socialist Youth International Union